

How many stars are there?

Our galaxy, called the Milky Way, has hundreds of billions of stars. There are trillions more galaxies in the universe, each containing countless stars. From the Earth, the Milky Way looks like a band of light in the night sky. If you could fly above our galaxy, it would look like a glittering wheel.

Galaxy shapes

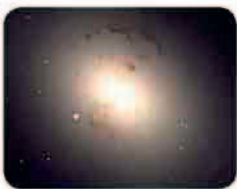
The shape of the Milky Way is called a barred spiral—it has a bar across its center that connects the spiral arms. Galaxies come in different shapes, such as these below.



Spiral



Lenticular



Elliptical



Irregular

★ Center of the galaxy

A black hole lies hidden in the center of our galaxy. It is called a “black” hole because nothing can escape this point, not even light.

3 Gas clouds